

Akhenaten

Location: the **western side of the Grand Staircase**, positioned near the escalator

Akhenaten, also spelled Akhenaton, Echnaton, and Khuenaten, was an ancient Egyptian pharaoh who reigned from approximately 1353 to 1336 BC or 1351 to 1334 BC. He was the tenth ruler of the Eighteenth Dynasty. Originally named Amenhotep IV, which means "Amun is satisfied", he adopted the name Akhenaten—meaning "Effective for the Aten"—in the fifth year of his reign.

As pharaoh, Akhenaten is famous for abandoning traditional, polytheistic ancient Egyptian religion to introduce Atenism, a worship system centered around the sun disk Aten.

After his death, this religious shift was quickly reversed. Akhenaten's monuments were dismantled and hidden, his statues were destroyed, and his name was left off official lists of kings compiled by later pharaohs. Traditional religious practices were restored under his successor, Tutankhamun, who dropped his original name, Tutankhaten, early in his reign. Later rulers from new dynasties discredited Akhenaten and his immediate successors, referring to him in official records as "the enemy of Akhetaten," "the enemy," or "that criminal."

Akhenaten was largely forgotten until the late 19th-century discovery of Amarna (originally Akhetaten), the new capital city he built for the worship of Aten. In 1907, a mummy that may be Akhenaten was unearthed from tomb KV55 in the Valley of the Kings. Genetic testing indicates this individual was Tutankhamun's biological father, though its exact identification as Akhenaten remains a topic of debate among scholars.

Public and scholarly interest in Akhenaten stems from his connection to Tutankhamun, the unique and high-quality artistic style he patronized, and his attempt to establish a religion that foreshadowed monotheism. Over the years, historians have described him variably as enigmatic, revolutionary, and idealist, but also as a heretic, fanatic, or mad.

Early Life

Akhenaten was born as Prince Amenhotep, a younger son of Pharaoh Amenhotep III and his principal wife, Queen Tiye, that means that his father is Amenhotep III and his mother is Queen Tiye. Based on the birth date of his eldest daughter, historians estimate he was born around 1363 to 1361 BC.

He had siblings, he had an elder brother, Crown Prince Thutmose, who was the recognized heir to the throne, as well as four or five sisters: Sitamun, Henuttaneb, Iset, Nebetah, and possibly Beketaten. When Thutmose died unexpectedly around his father's 30th regnal year, Amenhotep became next in line for the throne.

Very little is known about Akhenaten youth. An inscription on a wine docket suggests he may have been born at Amenhotep III's Malkata palace, while other historians propose he was born in

Memphis. Some scholars suggest he was influenced by the sun god Ra while growing up near Heliopolis, though solar worship was widespread throughout Egypt at the time.

The only figure confirmed by historical records as his childhood tutor is Parennefer. It has been speculated that after his brother's death, Amenhotep may have inherited Thutmose's position as High Priest of Ptah in Memphis—a role associated with the patron god of craftsmen, which some suggest influenced Akhenaten's later artistic interests.

Family and Consorts

Nefertiti and Secondary Wives

Akhenaten married Nefertiti, his Great Royal Wife, around the time he ascended the throne (possibly in his fourth regnal year).

He had several other recorded wives and consorts:

- **Kiya:** A prominent secondary wife who may have been the mother of Tutankhamun. Some historians theorize Kiya was actually Tadukhipa, a Mitanni princess who originally married Amenhotep III before becoming Akhenaten's wife.
- **Foreign Consorts:** Inscriptions confirm he took a daughter of the Enišasi ruler Šatiya and a daughter of the Babylonian king Burna-Buriash II as wives.

Children

Akhenaten had seven documented daughters:

- **Meritaten:** Born in regnal Year 1 or 5; later became Great Royal Wife to Pharaoh Smenkhkare.
- **Meketaten:** Born between Year 4 and 6; died around Year 13 or 14 at approximately age 10 to 12.
- **Ankhesenpaaten (later Ankhesenamun):** Born before Year 8; later became Great Royal Wife to Pharaoh Tutankhamun.
- **Neferneferuaten Tasherit:** Born in or before Year 9.
- **Neferneferure:** Born in Year 9 or 10.
- **Setepenre:** Born in Year 10 or 11.
- **An unnamed daughter:** Born to his secondary wife Kiya before Year 13.

Tutankhamun and Smenkhkare

Pharaoh Tutankhamun (originally Tutankhaten) was Akhenaten's son-in-law and is widely considered his biological son. Genetic testing from 2007 to 2009 showed that Tutankhamun's parents were the male mummy in tomb KV55 and a mummy known as "The Younger Lady"—identified genetically as a son and a daughter of Amenhotep III and Tiye. However, because there is no record of Akhenaten marrying his sisters, scholars debate these findings, suggesting

potential DNA contamination, extreme royal inbreeding, or alternative identities for the KV55 mummy (such as Smenkhkare).

Smenkhkare, who married Akhenaten's eldest daughter Meritaten, may have been Akhenaten's brother or a son by an unknown wife. Other researchers suggest Smenkhkare might actually be the same person as the female pharaoh Neferneferuaten (often identified as Nefertiti).

Theories on Incestuous Marriages

Some Egyptologists propose that Akhenaten took some of his own daughters as consorts to produce a male heir:

- **Meritaten:** Recorded on a box in Tutankhamun's tomb as Great Royal Wife alongside Akhenaten, and referred to as "mistress of the house" in foreign letters.
- **Meketaten:** Early scholars suggested she died in childbirth and that Akhenaten was the father, though modern researchers argue her tomb depictions represent her soul rather than a real child.
- **Grandchildren:** Reinscribed monuments list two children named Meritaten-tasherit ("junior") and Ankhesenpaaten-tasherit. Some scholars take this as evidence Akhenaten fathered children with his daughters, while others view these names as fictional additions created to cover up erased depictions of Kiya's child.

Here is the complete, clean version of this section focused on Akhenaten's reign, early rule, and name change. All citation brackets, footnotes, phonetic symbols, audio icons, and editorial annotations have been removed, while every single fact, date, scholar's argument, temple name, theory, and line of reasoning has been preserved.

Reign

Coregency with Amenhotep III

There is much controversy around whether Amenhotep IV ascended to Egypt's throne upon the death of his father Amenhotep III, or whether there was a coregency lasting perhaps as long as 12 years. Eric Cline, Nicholas Reeves, Peter Dorman, and other scholars argue strongly against the establishment of a long coregency between the two rulers and in favor of either no coregency or one lasting at most two years. Donald B. Redford, William J. Murnane, Alan Gardiner, and Lawrence Berman contest the view of any coregency whatsoever between Akhenaten and his father.

In 2014, archaeologists found both pharaohs' names inscribed on the wall of the Luxor tomb of vizier Amenhotep-Huy. The Egyptian Ministry of Antiquities called this "conclusive evidence" that Akhenaten shared power with his father for at least eight years, based on the dating of the tomb. However, this conclusion has since been called into question by other Egyptologists, according to whom the inscription only means that construction on Amenhotep-Huy's tomb

started during Amenhotep III's reign and ended under Akhenaten's, meaning Amenhotep-Huy simply wanted to pay his respects to both rulers.

Early Reign as Amenhotep IV

Akhenaten took Egypt's throne as Amenhotep IV, most likely in 1353 or 1351 BC. It is unknown how old Amenhotep IV was when he ascended the throne; estimates range from 10 to 23 years old. He was most likely crowned in Thebes, or less likely at Memphis or Armant.

The beginning of Amenhotep IV's reign followed established pharaonic traditions. He did not immediately start redirecting worship toward the Aten or distancing himself from other gods. Egyptologist Donald B. Redford believes this implies that Amenhotep IV's eventual religious policies were not conceived before his reign, and that he did not follow a pre-established plan or program. Redford points to three pieces of evidence to support this view:

1. **Continued Traditional Worship:** Surviving inscriptions show Amenhotep IV worshipping several different gods, including Atum, Osiris, Anubis, Nekhbet, Hathor, and the Eye of Ra. Texts from this era refer to "the gods" and "every god and every goddess." The High Priest of Amun was also still active in the fourth year of Amenhotep IV's reign.
2. **Honoring Thebes:** Even though he later moved his capital from Thebes to Akhetaten, his initial royal titulary honored Thebes—his nomen was "Amenhotep, god-ruler of Thebes." Recognizing its importance, he called the city "Southern Heliopolis, the first great seat of Re or the Disc."
3. **Preservation of Existing Temples:** Amenhotep IV did not yet destroy temples dedicated to other gods, and he even continued his father's construction projects at Karnak's Precinct of Amun-Re. He decorated the walls of the precinct's Third Pylon with images of himself worshipping Ra-Horakhty, portrayed in the god's traditional form as a falcon-headed man.

Artistic depictions also continued unchanged early in Amenhotep IV's reign. Tombs built or completed in the first few years after he took the throne—such as those of Kheruef, Ramose, and Parennefer—show the pharaoh in the traditional artistic style. In Ramose's tomb, Amenhotep IV appears on the west wall seated on a throne with Ramose standing before him; on the other side of the doorway, Amenhotep IV and Nefertiti are shown in the window of appearances with the Aten depicted as a sun disc. In Parennefer's tomb, Amenhotep IV and Nefertiti are seated on a throne with the sun disc depicted over the pharaoh and his queen.

While continuing the worship of other gods, Amenhotep IV's initial building program sought to construct new places of worship dedicated to the Aten. He ordered the construction of temples or shrines to the Aten in several cities across the country, including Bubastis, Tell el-Borg, Heliopolis, Memphis, Nekhen, Kawa, and Kerma.

He also ordered the construction of a large temple complex dedicated to the Aten at Karnak in Thebes, located northeast of the parts of the Karnak complex dedicated to Amun. The Aten

temple complex, collectively known as the Per Aten ("House of the Aten"), consisted of several temples whose names survive:

- **Gempaaten:** "The Aten is found in the estate of the Aten"
- **Hwt Benben:** "House or Temple of the Benben"
- **Rud-Menu:** "Enduring of monuments for Aten forever"
- **Teni-Menu:** "Exalted are the monuments of the Aten forever"
- **Sekhen Aten:** "Booth of Aten"

Around regnal year two or three, Amenhotep IV organized a Sed festival. Sed festivals were ritual rejuvenations of an aging pharaoh, which usually took place for the first time around the thirtieth year of a pharaoh's reign and every three or so years thereafter. Egyptologists can only speculate as to why Amenhotep IV organized a Sed festival when he was likely still in his early twenties:

- Some historians view it as evidence for a coregency between Amenhotep III and Amenhotep IV, believing that Amenhotep IV's Sed festival coincided with one of his father's celebrations.
- Others speculate that Amenhotep IV chose to hold his festival three years after his father's death to proclaim his rule a direct continuation of his father's reign.
- Yet others believe the festival was held to honor the Aten, on whose behalf the pharaoh ruled Egypt; or, since Amenhotep III was considered to have become one with the Aten following his death, the festival honored both the pharaoh and the god simultaneously.
- It is also possible that the purpose of the ceremony was to figuratively fill Amenhotep IV with strength before undertaking his great enterprise: introducing the Aten cult and founding the new capital of Akhetaten.

Regardless of the celebration's exact aim, Egyptologists believe that during the festivities Amenhotep IV made offerings exclusively to the Aten rather than to the many traditional gods and goddesses as was customary.

Name Change

Among the last documents that refer to the pharaoh as Amenhotep IV are two copies of a letter sent from Ipy, the high steward of Memphis. These letters, found at Gurob, inform the pharaoh that the royal estates in Memphis are "in good order" and the temple of Ptah is "prosperous and flourishing." They are dated to regnal year five, day nineteen of the growing season's third month. About a month later—on day thirteen of the growing season's fourth month—one of the boundary stela at Akhetaten already had the name Akhenaten carved on it, indicating that the pharaoh changed his name during that four-week window.

Amenhotep IV changed his royal titulary to demonstrate his complete devotion to the Aten. No longer would he be known as Amenhotep IV or be associated with the god Amun.

Egyptologists debate the exact translation of his new personal name, Akhenaten. The Ancient Egyptian word *akh* can have several meanings, such as "satisfied," "effective spirit," or "serviceable to." Consequently, translations of Akhenaten include:

- "Aten is satisfied"
- "Effective spirit of the Aten"
- "Serviceable to the Aten"

Gertie Englund and Florence Friedman arrive at the translation "Effective for the Aten" by analyzing contemporary texts and inscriptions in which Akhenaten frequently describes himself as being "effective for" the sun disc. They conclude that the frequency with which he used this phrase indicates that his name meant "Effective for the Aten."

Additionally, some historians—including William F. Albright, Edel Elmar, and Gerhard Fecht—propose that Akhenaten's name is misspelled and mispronounced in modern usage. They argue that "Aten" should actually be read as "Jāti," rendering the pharaoh's name Akhenjāti or Aḥanjāti in Ancient Egyptian.

Founding Amarna

Around the same time he changed his royal titulary, on the thirteenth day of the growing season's fourth month, Akhenaten decreed that a new capital city be built: Akhetaten (meaning "Horizon of the Aten"), better known today as Amarna.

The events Egyptologists know the most about during Akhenaten's life are connected with the founding of Akhetaten, as several boundary stela were carved around the site to mark its limits. The pharaoh selected a previously uninhabited site on the east bank of the Nile, roughly halfway between the existing capital of Thebes and the northern city of Memphis. Here, a wadi and a natural dip in the surrounding cliffs formed a silhouette mimicking the Egyptian hieroglyph for "horizon."

According to inscriptions on one boundary stela, the site was chosen because it belonged to no previous deity or ruler, being:

"not being the property of a god, nor being the property of a goddess, nor being the property of a ruler, nor being the property of a female ruler, nor being the property of any people able to lay claim to it."

Historians do not know for certain why Akhenaten established a new capital and abandoned Thebes. The boundary stela detailing Akhetaten's founding are damaged where they likely explained his exact motives. Surviving portions claim that events had occurred during his reign that were "worse than those that I heard" previously and worse than those "heard by any kings who assumed the White Crown," while also alluding to offensive speech directed against the Aten. Egyptologists, such as Donald B. Redford, believe Akhenaten was referring to an escalating conflict with the priesthood of Amun, the patron deity of Thebes. The priests of Amun

at Karnak had amassed immense wealth and political power during the Eighteenth Dynasty—particularly under Hatshepsut and Thutmose III—and moving to a new capital allowed Akhenaten to break away from both the god Amun and his powerful priesthood.

Layout and Construction

Akhetaten was a meticulously planned city featuring the Great Temple of the Aten, the Small Aten Temple, royal residences, a records office, and central government buildings. Construction proceeded at an unprecedented speed thanks to a new building technique using standardized, smaller limestone blocks known as *talatats*.

- **Talatats Dimensions:** Measuring 1/2 by 1/2 by 1 ancient Egyptian cubit (approximately 27 by 27 by 54 cm), these blocks were lightweight enough for single workers to carry, dramatically speeding up construction compared to traditional massive blocks.
- **Timeline of the Move:** By regnal year eight, Akhetaten was sufficiently built for the royal family and his loyal supporters to move in. Between regnal years five and eight, construction work on Aten temples in Thebes ground to a halt, and the tomb workers' village at the Valley of the Kings was relocated to the workers' village at Akhetaten. However, construction of Aten temples continued in other major religious centers across Egypt, including Heliopolis and Memphis.

International Relations and Foreign Policy

Information regarding Akhenaten's foreign policy comes primarily from the **Amarna Letters**—a cache of 382 diplomatic clay tablets, literary texts, and educational materials discovered between 1887 and 1979 at Akhetaten. The collection contains correspondence between Egyptian pharaohs (Amenhotep III, Akhenaten, and Tutankhamun), Egyptian military outpost commanders, Asiatic vassal rulers, and independent foreign monarchs from Babylonia, Assyria, Syria, Canaan, Alashiya, Arzawa, Mitanni, and the Hittite Empire.

Shift in Regional Power

Akhenaten inherited a complex diplomatic landscape. Following the expulsion of the Hyksos 200 years prior, Egypt had expanded its military footprint, reaching peak dominance under Thutmose III roughly a century before Akhenaten. Though early expansion caused conflicts with the Mitanni kingdom, Egypt eventually established a peaceful alliance with them. By Amenhotep III's reign, Egypt maintained regional stability through diplomatic marriages (such as Amenhotep III marrying the Mitanni princess Tadukhipa) and vassal relationships.

However, during the reigns of Amenhotep III and Akhenaten, the aggressive Hittite Empire under King Šuppiluliuma I began expanding rapidly into Syria, defeating the Mitanni and threatening Egypt's network of vassal states.

Conflict with Vassals and the Fate of Rib-Hadda

As Hittite influence expanded, several Egyptian vassals in northern Syria switch allegiances. Allies who attempted to resist the Hittites wrote desperate letters begging Akhenaten for military support, but most pleas went unanswered.

This regional instability triggered internal conflicts within Canaan:

- **Canaanite Conflicts:** Struggles for regional control between Labaya of Shechem and Abdi-Heba of Jerusalem forced Akhenaten to intervene by dispatching police forces (Medjay) northwards.
- **The Fall of Byblos:** Rib-Hadda, the ruler of Byblos, sent over 60 frantic letters to Akhenaten begging for help against Abdi-Ashirta and his son Aziru, rulers of the expanding border state of Amurru. Akhenaten grew weary of Rib-Hadda's constant communications, writing to him in letter EA 124: *"You are the one that writes to me more than all the other mayors."* Akhenaten was unwilling to mobilize a full imperial army to preserve the local politics of minor border city-states. Consequently, Rib-Hadda was ousted in a coup by his brother Ilirabih, fled to his enemy Aziru for assistance, and was promptly handed over to the King of Sidon and executed.

Debating Akhenaten's Military Strategy

Historians historically disagreed on Akhenaten's competence in international affairs:

- **Older View (Pacifism/Neglect):** Late 19th- and 20th-century Egyptologists like Henry Hall and James Henry Breasted argued that Akhenaten was an impractical pacifist whose devotion to religious reform caused him to lose control of Egypt's foreign territory.
- **Modern View (Strategic Realpolitik):** 21st-century Egyptology discounts the pacifist theory. Scholars like Norman de Garis Davies and James Baikie point out that no rebellions occurred within Egypt proper during his reign, and the Amarna letters show that Egyptian military units, archers, chariots, cavalry, and ships were frequently dispatched by both Amenhotep III and Akhenaten. Akhenaten successfully maintained control over core Egyptian territory in Canaan and the Phoenician coast while avoiding a costly, full-scale war with the powerful Hittite Empire. Only the northern border province of Amurru was lost when its leader, Aziru, defected to the Hittites.

Known Military Campaigns

While diplomatic reports dominated his reign, military activity did occur:

1. **The Nubian Campaign:** In either regnal year two or twelve, Akhenaten ordered Tuthmose, the Viceroy of Kush, to lead a military expedition into Nubia to suppress raids by nomadic tribes. Victory was recorded on stelae at Amada and Buhen. Egyptologists debate its scale: Wolfgang Helck viewed it as a minor police action, while Alan Schulman considered it a major military campaign.
2. **Levantine/Syrian Operations:** Several Egyptologists argue Akhenaten conducted military actions in the Levant against Hittite forces:
 - Cyril Aldred proposed an campaign near Gezer.

- Marc Gabolde proposed an campaign near Kadesh.
- John Coleman Darnell and Colleen Manassa argued Akhenaten fought the Hittites for control of Kadesh but failed to capture it (the city was not reclaimed by Egypt until 60 to 70 years later under Seti I).
- These campaigns align with a passage on Tutankhamun's later Restoration Stela, which notes that when armies were sent to Djahy (southern Canaan and Syria) to expand Egypt's borders, they met with no success.

Later Years and Plague

The final five years of Akhenaten's reign (beginning around 1341 or 1339 BC) are poorly documented, making it one of the most contested periods in Egyptology.

The Year 12 Reception

Before recent discoveries, the last firmly dated major event in his reign was a grand royal reception in regnal year twelve. Reliefs in the tomb of the courtier Meryre II show Akhenaten, Nefertiti, and all six of their daughters receiving foreign tribute from Nubia, Punt, Syria, the Hittite Kingdom, Libya, and the Mediterranean islands. Egyptologist Aidan Dodson considers this event the peak of Akhenaten's reign. Proposed reasons for this grand gathering include:

- The marriage of the future pharaoh Ay to Tey.
- Akhenaten's twelve-year jubilee on the throne.
- The formal summoning of King Aziru of Amurru to Egypt.
- Celebrating a military victory at Sumur or in Nubia.
- Nefertiti's elevation to co-regent.
- The official completion of the capital city Akhetaten.

The Deir el-Bersha Inscription

In 2012, archaeologists discovered a limestone quarry inscription at Deir el-Bersha (just north of Amarna) dated to **Year 16, month 3 of Akhet, day 15** of Akhenaten's reign. The inscription mentions a building project at Amarna and confirms that Akhenaten and Nefertiti were still ruling together as a royal couple just one year prior to his death.

Outbreak of Epidemic

Following year twelve, evidence suggests a widespread epidemic or plague swept across Egypt and the Near East. Scholars suggest the disease may have been introduced to Amarna by foreign delegations attending the year twelve reception, or conversely, brought from Egypt to the Near East by prisoners of war. This outbreak is believed to account for the sudden deaths of several members of the royal family in Akhenaten's final years, including three of his daughters: Meketaten, Neferneferure, and Setepenre.

Co-Regencies: Smenkhkare and Nefertiti

To secure the succession during the epidemic, Akhenaten appears to have appointed co-regents in his final years:

- **Smenkhkare:** Depictions in tombs (such as Meryre II) and artifacts from Tutankhamun's tomb indicate Smenkhkare became co-regent around regnal year thirteen or fourteen, but died within one or two years. Smenkhkare was married to Akhenaten's eldest daughter, Meritaten, and may have been Akhenaten's son or his younger brother (a son of Amenhotep III by Queen Tiye or Sitamun).
- **Nefertiti / Neferneferuaten:** Nefertiti may have been elevated to co-regent alongside or after Smenkhkare (around or after regnal year sixteen). The *Coregency Stela* found at Amarna appears to depict Nefertiti as co-ruler, though the inscription was later recarved with the names of Ankhesenpaaten and Neferneferuaten.
- **Dodson's Succession Theory:** Egyptologist Aidan Dodson proposed that Akhenaten appointed both Smenkhkare and Nefertiti as co-regents to safeguard the Amarna line during the plague. This structure ensured that if Akhenaten died while Prince Tutankhaten was still a child, the co-regents could govern on his behalf—or rule in his place if the young prince also succumbed to the epidemic.

Death and Burial

Akhenaten died in his 17th regnal year, as evidenced by wine dockets found at Amarna.

He was initially buried in a royal tomb cut into the Royal Wadi east of Akhetaten. The order to construct this tomb was commemorated on one of the capital's boundary stelae:

"Let a tomb be made for me in the eastern mountain [of Akhetaten]. Let my burial be made in it, in the millions of jubilees which the Aten, my father, decreed for me."

Akhenaten's burial chamber is easily identifiable in the Royal Tomb of Akhenaten because it is the only chamber that was fully finished; the rest of the complex consists of unfinished rock-cut rooms meant to inter other royal family members, such as Queen Nefertiti. Work on the tomb ceased entirely when the royal court abandoned Amarna and returned to Thebes under Akhenaten's son, Tutankhamun, roughly three years after Akhenaten's death.

Sarcophagus and Reburial in KV55

In the years following his burial, Akhenaten's sarcophagus was smashed and left in the Akhetaten necropolis. It was later reconstructed in the 20th century and housed in the Egyptian Museum in Cairo.

Despite the sarcophagus being destroyed on site, Akhenaten's mummy was removed from Amarna after Tutankhamun abandoned the city. It was most likely transferred to tomb **KV55** in

the Valley of the Kings near Thebes. This tomb was later desecrated, likely during the Ramesside period.

Royal Succession Immediately Following Death

Whether Smenkhkare enjoyed a brief independent reign after Akhenaten remains unclear. If Smenkhkare outlived Akhenaten to become sole pharaoh, he likely ruled for less than a year. The next successor is thought by some to be Nefertiti or Meritaten, ruling under the royal name **Neferneferuaten** for approximately two years. She was likely succeeded by Tutankhaten, with the nation's administration guided by the vizier (and future pharaoh) Ay.

The KV55 Mummy Identification Controversy

The identification of the male mummy discovered in tomb KV55 in 1907 remains controversial:

- **The 2010 DNA Study:** A team led by Egyptologist Zahi Hawass conducted medical and genetic testing, publishing results in 2010 that identified the KV55 mummy as the biological father of Tutankhamun and "most probably" Akhenaten.
- **Scholarly Rebuttals:** Critics point out that the study failed to address that Tutankhamun's father and any paternal uncles would share identical genetic markers. Thus, if the mummy was Tutankhamun's father, it could equally be a brother of Akhenaten, such as Smenkhkare.
- **The Daughter/Grandchild Genetic Dilemma:** Genetic testing also indicates that the KV55 mummy cannot be the maternal grandfather of Tutankhamun's two stillborn daughters (conceived with Ankhesenamun, Akhenaten's daughter). Juan Belmonte notes three possible explanations for this anomaly:
 1. Tutankhamun fathered the two princesses with a different consort.
 2. The KV55 mummy is not Akhenaten, but Smenkhkare (considered by Belmonte to be the most probable option).
 3. The KV55 mummy is Akhenaten, but he was not the biological father of Ankhesenamun due to an extramarital affair by Nefertiti (considered historical speculation).

Legacy and Destruction of the Amarna Period

Following Akhenaten's death, the Aten cult fell out of favor—initially gradually, and then with decisive finality:

1. **Tutankhamun's Reversal:** In Year 2 of his reign (c. 1332 BC), Tutankhaten changed his name to Tutankhamun and abandoned the city of Akhetaten.
2. **Systematic Eradication:** Subsequent rulers worked to erase Akhenaten and his immediate family from historical records. His name was hacked off monuments, and

administrative records referred to him simply as "the enemy of Akhetaten," "the enemy," or "that criminal" (as seen in the tomb of the scribe Mose/Mes).

3. **Dismantling Buildings:** During the reign of Horemheb (the last pharaoh of the 18th Dynasty), Egyptians began dismantling Aten temples and using the recycled stone blocks (*talatats*) as structural infill for new building projects, including temples dedicated to Amun.
4. **Erasure from King Lists:** Seti I restored damaged monuments to Amun and re-carved the god's name over erased areas. Seti I ordered Akhenaten, Smenkhkare, Neferneferuaten, Tutankhamun, and Ay to be completely excised from official king lists, making it appear that Amenhotep III was directly succeeded by Horemheb.
5. **Ramesside Destruction:** Under the Nineteenth and Twentieth Dynasties, Akhetaten was systematically stripped for building materials, which were reused across Egypt in locations like Hermopolis.

Long-Term Impact on Egyptian Religion and Society

Egyptologists like Jacobus van Dijk and Jan Assmann argue that the Amarna period triggered a long-term decline in the absolute power of the pharaoh:

- **Pre-Amarna Relationship:** Prior to Akhenaten, the pharaoh was viewed as the living incarnation of Horus and the sole representative of the gods on Earth. However, ordinary citizens maintained a close personal connection to local deities through public festivals, processions, and holidays.
- **Amarna Disruption:** Akhenaten banned these festivals, outlawed traditional gods, and forced all religious devotion through himself as the exclusive intermediary to the Aten.
- **Post-Amarna Shift (Direct Piety):** When traditional religion returned under the Ramesside era, citizens no longer relied on the pharaoh to access the divine. Ordinary Egyptians began believing that gods intervened directly in human lives to protect the pious and punish criminals. The gods—not the pharaoh—became their own representatives on Earth.
- **Rise of the Amun Priesthood:** As Amun was recognized as the ultimate divine king, the political authority of earthly pharaohs was reduced. This structural shift allowed the power of the High Priests of Amun to steadily expand until the Twenty-first Dynasty (c. 1077 BC), by which time the priesthood effectively ruled over Upper Egypt.

Impact on Language

Akhenaten's reign accelerated a permanent shift in written Egyptian. Spoken and written Egyptian had diverged early in history, but during the Amarna period, official royal inscriptions, boundary stelae, and diplomatic letters began incorporating the spoken vernacular (Late Egyptian), including definite articles and new possessive forms. Although later pharaohs attempted to reverse his policies, these Late Egyptian linguistic forms remained a permanent standard in official literature from the Nineteenth Dynasty onward.

Atenism

Pre-Existing Solar Cults

Solar worship had been growing throughout the Eighteenth Dynasty, particularly under Amenhotep III. New Kingdom pharaohs were frequently linked to the sun disc; for example, Hatshepsut was called "female Re shining like the Disc," and Amenhotep III was called "the dazzling disc."

In his 30th regnal year, Amenhotep III adopted the epithet *Aten-Tjeheh* ("the Dazzling Sun Disk"), elevating the Aten from a minor solar aspect into a deity with royal patronage, and named his daughter Beketaten ("Handmaid of Aten"). However, Amenhotep III did not promote Aten exclusively; his primary devotion remained with Amun-Ra.

Development and Phases of Atenism

Donald B. Redford divides the implementation of Atenism into three distinct developmental stages:

1. **Earliest Stage:** Increased depictions of the sun disc, though still shown resting on the head of the traditional falcon-headed god Ra-Horakhty. The god was treated as unique, but not exclusive.
2. **Intermediate Stage:** The Aten was elevated above all other deities, and its name began appearing inside royal cartouches.
3. **Final Stage:** The Aten was depicted strictly as a bare solar disc with extending rays that terminated in human hands, taking on the official epithet: *"the great living Disc which is in jubilee, lord of heaven and earth."*

Architectural and Ideological Shift

Early in his reign at Thebes, Amenhotep IV permitted traditional worship while favoring the Aten. Theban inscriptions in Parennefer's tomb note that payments to other gods were measured with a level measure, but payments to the Aten "overflowed."

Amenhotep IV built new Aten temples at Karnak without roofs, allowing the god to be worshipped directly under open sunlight rather than inside dark inner sanctuaries. (Archaeologists later recovered roughly 36,000 decorated blocks from these dismantled structures).

In a year-two speech preserved on a Karnak pylon, Amenhotep IV declared that traditional gods had grown ineffective, their bodies had ceased to endure, and their temples had fallen into ruin—contrasting them with the self-created, eternal sun disc.

"The temples of the gods fallen to ruin, their bodies do not endure.
Since the time of the ancestors, it is the wise man that knows these things.

Behold, I, the king, am speaking so that I might inform you concerning the appearances of the gods. I know their temples, and I am versed in the writings, specifically, the inventory of their primeval bodies. And I have watched as they [the gods] have ceased their appearances, one after the other.

All of them have stopped, except the god who gave birth to himself. And no one knows the mystery of how he performs his tasks. This god goes where he pleases and no one else knows his going. I approach him, the things which he has made. How exalted they are."

Complete Monotheism (Year 5 to Year 9)

- **Year 5:** Amenhotep IV officially changed his name to Akhenaten, disbanded traditional priesthoods, and redirected cult incomes to the Aten. The Aten itself was treated as a ruling king, depicted wearing a uraeus cobra, and having its name written in royal cartouches.
- **Year 9:** Akhenaten declared the Aten to be the sole universal god, banning all other deities. He ordered the defacing of Amun's temples nationwide and erased plural references to "gods." All physical imagery was banned except for the rayed sun disc.
- **Name Changes of the God:** Between years eight and fourteen, the god's official title was modified from "*Living Re-Horakhty, who rejoices in the horizon in his name Shu-Re who is in Aten*" to "*Living Re, ruler of the horizon, who rejoices in his name of Re the father who has returned as Aten*", severing traditional links to the older deities Re-Horakhty and Shu.

The Great Hymn to the Aten

Found carved in the tomb of the courtier (and future pharaoh) Ay, the *Great Hymn to the Aten* is attributed directly to Akhenaten. It praises the sun as the sole creator and sustainer of all life, highlighting the world's dependence on light and the dangers of darkness:

"O Sole God beside whom there is none! You made the earth as you wished, you alone."

The hymn reinforces Akhenaten's role as the single intermediary between divinity and humanity, stating:

"You are in my heart, and there is none who knows you except your son."

Here is the complete, cleaned-up text for this section on Atenism, other gods, and the period following Akhenaten. All citation brackets ([222], [223], etc.) have been removed, while every single date, historical detail, quote, deity reference, archaeological evidence, and name change has been fully preserved.

Atenism and Other Gods

Some debate has focused on the extent to which Akhenaten forced his religious reforms on his people. Certainly, as time drew on, he revised the names of the Aten, and other religious

language, to increasingly exclude references to other gods; at some point, also, he embarked on the wide-scale erasure of traditional gods' names, especially those of Amun.

Some of his court changed their names to remove them from the patronage of other gods and place them under that of Aten (or Ra, with whom Akhenaten equated the Aten). Yet, even at Amarna itself, some courtiers kept such names as Ahmose ("child of the moon god", the owner of tomb 3), and the sculptor's workshop where the famous Nefertiti Bust and other works of royal portraiture were found is associated with an artist known to have been called Thutmose ("child of Thoth").

An overwhelmingly large number of faience amulets at Amarna also show that talismans of the household-and-childbirth gods Bes and Taweret, the eye of Horus, and amulets of other traditional deities, were openly worn by its citizens. Indeed, a cache of royal jewelry found buried near the Amarna royal tombs (now in the National Museum of Scotland) includes a finger ring referring to Mut, the wife of Amun. Such evidence suggests that though Akhenaten shifted funding away from traditional temples, his policies were fairly tolerant until some point, perhaps a particular event as yet unknown, toward the end of the reign.

Archaeological discoveries at Akhetaten show that many ordinary residents of this city chose to gouge or chisel out all references to the god Amun on even minor personal items that they owned, such as commemorative scarabs or make-up pots, perhaps for fear of being accused of having Amunist sympathies. References to Amenhotep III, Akhenaten's father, were partly erased since they contained the traditional Amun form of his name: Nebmaatre Amunhotep.

After Akhenaten

Following Akhenaten's death, Egypt gradually returned to its traditional polytheistic religion, partly because of how closely associated the Aten became with Akhenaten. Atenism likely stayed dominant through the reigns of Akhenaten's immediate successors, Smenkhkare and Neferneferuaten, as well as early in the reign of Tutankhaten. For some years the worship of Aten and a resurgent worship of Amun coexisted.

A key reason the cult of Aten failed under Akhenaten was due to its lack of afterlife beliefs. The traditional Osirian cult offered an opportunity for Egyptians to access an idealised vision of one's life on Earth after they had died in the Field of Reeds or A'aru. This was replaced with a continued existence in the present.

Over time, however, Akhenaten's successors, starting with Tutankhaten, took steps to distance themselves from Atenism. Tutankhaten and his wife Ankhesenpaaten dropped the Aten from their names and changed them to Tutankhamun and Ankhesenamun, respectively. Amun was restored as the supreme deity.

Tutankhamun reestablished the temples of the other gods, as the pharaoh propagated on his Restoration Stela:

"He reorganized this land, restoring its customs to those of the time of Re. ... He renewed the gods' mansions and fashioned all their images. ... He raised up their temples and created their statues. ... When he had sought out the gods' precincts which were in ruins in this land, he refounded them just as they had been since the time of the first primeval age."

Additionally, Tutankhamun's building projects at Thebes and Karnak used talatat from Akhenaten's buildings, which implies that Tutankhamun might have started to demolish temples dedicated to the Aten. Aten temples continued to be torn down under Ay and Horemheb, Tutankhamun's successors and the last pharaohs of the Eighteenth Dynasty. Horemheb might also have ordered the demolition of Akhetaten, Akhenaten's capital city. Further underlining the break with Aten worship, Horemheb claimed to have been chosen to rule by the god Horus. Finally, Seti I, the second pharaoh of the Nineteenth Dynasty, ordered the name of Amun to be restored on inscriptions where it had been removed or replaced by Aten.

Important Dates:

- **c. 1380 BCE / 1362 BCE: Birth of Akhenaten** (born Prince Amenhotep), son of Pharaoh Amenhotep III and Queen Tiye.
- **c. 1353 BCE (or 1351 BCE): Accession to the throne** as **Amenhotep IV** following the death of his father.
- **c. 1352 BCE (Regnal Year 2):** Delivers a speech at Karnak declaring older deities ineffective and begins constructing open-air Aten temples at Thebes.
- **c. 1349 BCE (Regnal Year 5):**
 - Officially changes his name from Amenhotep IV to **Akhenaten** ("Effective for the Aten").
 - Issues boundary stelae founding the new royal capital of **Akhetaten** ("Horizon of the Aten," modern Tell el-Amarna).
- **c. 1345 BCE (Regnal Year 9):**
 - Proclaims Aten to be the sole universal god, outlawing worship of other deities.
 - Directs nationwide campaigns to erase the names and images of Amun and plural references to "gods".
- **c. 1342 BCE (Regnal Year 12):** Celebrates the "Durbar of Year 12," a massive state ceremony receiving foreign tribute depicted in several Amarna tombs.
- **c. 1336 BCE / 1334 BCE (Regnal Year 17): Death of Akhenaten** at roughly 38 years of age. He was initially interred in the Royal Tomb of Akhetaten and later moved (likely to tomb KV55 in the Valley of the Kings).

Summary:

Birth, Names & Titles

- **Birth Name:** Prince Amenhotep (*Amenhotep IV* upon ascending the throne), meaning "Amun is pleased."
- **Regnal Name Change:** Changed his name in his 5th regnal year (c. 1349 BCE) to **Akhenaten**, meaning "Effective for the Aten" or "Living spirit of the Aten."

- **Estimated Birth Year:** Circa 1380 BCE or 1362 BCE (exact date unknown).
- **Estimated Age at Death:** Approximately 35 to 40 years old.

Family & Lineage

- **Parents:**
 - **Father:** Pharaoh Amenhotep III (18th Dynasty).
 - **Mother:** Great Royal Wife Tiye.
- **Primary Consort / Great Royal Wife:**
 - **Nefertiti** (*Neferneferuaten Nefertiti*), who held prominent religious and political status during his reign and was depicted as near-equal in royal iconography.
- **Secondary Wives & Consorts:**
 - **Kiya:** A beloved lesser wife who held titles like "The Favorite" (*Ta-shent*).
 - **Tadukhipa:** A Mittani princess sent to Egypt to cement a diplomatic alliance (often hypothesized by some Egyptologists to be Kiya or Nefertiti).
- **Children:**
 - **Daughters (with Nefertiti):** Meritaten, Meketaten, Ankhesenpaaten (later Ankhesenamun), Neferneferuaten Tasherit, Neferneferure, and Setepenre.
 - **Son: Tutankhaten** (later Tutankhamun), confirmed by 2010 DNA studies to be Akhenaten's biological son (likely mothered by Kiya or an unnamed sister of Akhenaten known as the "Younger Lady").
 - **Smenkhkare:** Hypothesized by some researchers to be another son or younger brother of Akhenaten.

Physical Characteristics & Health

- **Iconographic Style:** Contemporary Amarna art depicted him with distinct, elongated physical features: a long face, prominent chin, full lips, thin neck, pronounced sloped abdomen, wide hips, and thin limbs.
- **Medical Hypotheses:** Scholars and medical professionals have debated his health, suggesting various conditions to explain his artistic depictions:
 - **Froehlich's Syndrome / Marfan Syndrome / Antley-Bixler Syndrome:** Proposed theories regarding potential genetic or hormonal conditions (though largely disputed by modern forensic and genetic tests).
 - **Family Resemblance:** DNA and skeletal studies of the KV55 mummy show natural anatomical traits (such as a dolichocephalic/elongated skull) shared across the 18th Dynasty royal lineage rather than a severe pathology.

Personal Beliefs & Religious Identity

- **Self-Conception:** Viewed himself as the physical son and sole earthly intermediary of the sun god **Aten**.
- **Literary/Religious Contributions:** Authored or directly commissioned *The Great Hymn to the Aten*, expressing personal theological devotion to a single, universal solar deity.

- **Rejection of Tradition:** Actively broke from centuries of Egyptian religious tradition by banning the cult of Amun and other traditional deities, closing their temples, and redirecting royal patronage exclusively to the sun disc.

Death & Burial

- **Date of Death:** Died in his 17th regnal year (c. 1336 BCE / 1334 BCE).
- **Original Resting Place:** Interred in the Royal Tomb cut into the cliffs at his capital, Akhetaten (Amarna).
- **Reburial:** Following the abandonment of Amarna, his body was moved to Thebes and is widely identified by genetic testing as the male mummy discovered in **KV55** in the Valley of the Kings.